

Mere Exposure Effect

What is it?

People like things more simply because they see them repeatedly.

History

First identified in social psychology research around **1968**, demonstrating that repeated exposure to an object increases preference and emotional familiarity — even if people don't consciously notice it.

The Psychology Behind It

- Familiarity feels safe and trustworthy
- Repetition builds emotional comfort automatically
- Users develop preference without deep analysis
- The brain interprets repeated visuals as more credible

Why It Matters

- Builds trust
- Strengthens brand loyalty
- Can bias user decisions
- Risk of visual fatigue if overused

How to Apply It

- Keep branding consistent across all touchpoints
- Reuse core visual patterns and microcopy
- Reinforce CTAs using subtle repetition
- Introduce major design changes gradually
- Balance repetition with small refreshing tweaks

Theory in Action

- Facebook maintains consistent blue and white branding for familiarity and trust
- McDonald's uses its golden arches and red/yellow color system globally to strengthen recognition

Final Thought

Repetition shapes preference.

Consistent exposure creates familiarity — and familiarity creates trust.